tions which he afterwards wove into one of the most remarkable descriptions we possess of any medieval Muslim court. Little did Sultan or courtiers think that six centuries afterwards their reputations would depend on the notes and reminiscences of the obscure and spendthrift qádí from the West. At last the inevitable rupture occurred, whose consequences were usually swift and fatal to the victim of the royal displeasure. Ibn Battúta took refuge in his last resort, the adoption of the ascetic life, resigning all his offices and giving away all his possessions. It was a genuine act of world-renuncaition, such as always lay near to the heart of the medieval theologian, and seems to have convinced Sultan Muhammad of the traveller's real integrity and devotion. At all events, when he required shortly afterwards a trustworthy person to send as his envoy to China, it was Ibn Battúta whom he summoned. Ibn Battúta, for his part, it would seem, was reluctant to doff his hermit's garments and "become entangled in the world again." But the bribe was too great, and in 1342 he set off in semi-regal state at the head of the mission to the most powerful ruler in the world of his time, the Mongol Emperor of China.

Scarcely had he left the walls of Delhi when his adventures began. For eight days he was a hunted fugitive, and though he escaped to rejoin his embassy in its progress through India, it was only to be left with nothing but the clothes he stood up in and his prayer-mat on the shore at Calicut. To go on with his mission in the circumstances was impossible; to return to Dehli was to incur the wrath of Sultan Muhammad. He chose instead to indulge his love of adventure with the independent rulers of the Malabar coast, and eventually found himself at the Maldive Islands, once again a qádí and a personage of importance. Here too after eighteen months of lotos-

eating his reforming zeal made of him an object of suspicion and dislike, and he found it expedient to leave the islands. The devotee in him again asserted itself, and his first object was to make a pilgrimage to the "Foot of Adam" on the highest peak of Ceylon. This done he returned to the Coromandel and Malabar coasts, paid another brief visit to the Maldive Islands and prepared in earnest for his journey to China. Some months had still to elapse before the sailing season, however, and he chose to spend them in a voyage to Bengal, for no other reason, apparently, than to visit a famous shaykh living in Assam. He then intercepted the "Chinese" vessels—really vessels owned by Muhammadan merchants, with Chinese and Malay crews—at Sumatra and went by a route that has taxed the ingenuity of his commentators to the "Shanghai" of China in the thirteenth and fourteenth centuries, the port of Ts'wan-chow-fu, or Zaytún, as it was known to the foreign merchants. For this journey Ibn Battúta reassumed his role of ambassador, though it may strike us as curious that no one seemed to entertain any suspicions of an ambassador who travelled without embassy or credentials. It was, however, his only device for making his way through China, though his theological reputation stood him in good stead amongst his fellow-Muslims in the trading ports. In every city on his progress to and from Peking he was received with full honours, but at Peking itself he was disappointed of seeing the Emperor, owing to his absence from the capital.

Returning to Zaytún, he took ship again for Sumatra, and thence for Malabar, but decided not to expose himself a second time to the treacherous splendours of Delhi, and made westwards instead. He was in Syria at the outbreak of the first "Black Death" in 1348, and in a few terse sentences reveals its frightful ravages. At this time he seems to have had no defi-

nite plans for the future, and was aiming only at completing yet another Pilgrimage, his seventh, to Mecca. What eventually led him to return to his native land is not clear. His own narrative places more weight on the rapid access of strength and prosperity which Morocco enjoyed under Sultan Abu'l-Hasan and his son Abú 'Inán, than on those ties of family and kindred which appear to us so much more natural a reason. Possibly allowances should be made for the part of exaggeration and flattery, but the brevity of his stay in Tangier, and the unemotional, almost brusque, manner in which he mentions it, scarcely witness to an overmastering homesickness, which, in any case, was hardly to be expected in a society so cosmopolitan as that of medieval Islam.

The journey from Alexandria to the Barbary coast was not without its alarms. Twice Ibn Battúta narrowly escaped capture by Christian corsairs, and in addition his party was threatened by a robber band almost within sight of Fez. Even yet his ambition was not appeased. There were still two Muslim countries which he had not visited—Andalusia and the Negrolands on the Niger. Once again he took up the staff of travel, not to lay it down again until some three years later he could claim with justice the title of "The Traveller of Islam." He was in fact the only medieval traveller who is known to have visited the lands of every Muhammadan ruler of his time, quite apart from such infidel countries as Constantinople, Ceylon, and China, which were embraced in his journeys. The mere extent of his wanderings is estimated by Yule at not less than 75,000 miles, without allowing for deviations, a figure which is not likely to have been surpassed before the age of steam.

Unfortunately no account of Ibn Battúta has come down to us (so far as is known) from anyone who saw him on his journeys. There appear to be only two

known references to him in the writings of contemporaries, and both are concerned chiefly with the credibility of his ſtories, which was hotly disputed. What they thought of him personally we are not told, but are able to infer occasionally from his own candid ſtatements. Twice we find him, after receiving a cordial welcome, becoming an objeſt of dislike or suspicion, at Delhi and again in the Maldive Islands. In the firſt case the cause was his extravagance, in the second it was fear of his growing influence and resentment at his haughty independence. There can be no queſtion that he expeſted of princes and miniſters a lavish exercise of the virtue of generosity, which was indeed in his eyes—as in those of his age and community generally—their principal claim to respeſt. It may be taken as a general rule that when Ibn Battúta says of this or the other prince that he is "a good sultan" or "one of the beſt of rulers," he means only that he is scrupulous in the performance of his religious duties and openhanded in his dealings, especially with theologians. We can well underſtand that this attitude was apt to pall on his patrons and lead at length to unpleasant incidents, or at least mutual dislike. Apart from these rare cases, however, he appears to have been liked and respeſted wherever he went.

In attempting to eſtimate the value of Ibn Battúta's work, some description muſt be given of the book itself. Ibn Battúta *may* have taken notes of the places that he visited, but the evidence is rather againſt it. Only once does he refer to notes, when he says that at Bukhárá he copied a number of epitaphs from the tombs of famous scholars, but afterwards loſt them when the Indian pirates ſtripped him of all that he had. These epitaphs were of special intereſt to men of letters and theologians because they contained liſts of the writings of the deceased. Ibn

Battúta was not himself a man of letters who was likely to regard his experiences as material for a book; on the contrary, he seems to have entertained no idea of writing them down.

On his return to Fez he had related his adventures to the sultan and the court, where they were received with general incredulity, as we know from a passage in the works of his great contemporary, the historian Ibn Khaldún. He found, however, a powerful supporter in the wazír, at whose instigation possibly the sultan gave instructions to one of the principal secretaries, Muhammad ibn Juzayy, to commit them to writing. Ibn Juzayy accordingly compiled the work which we possess at the dictation of Ibn Battúta. The result is a book of somewhat composite character. The writer was not always content to take down Ibn Battúta's narratives as they were delivered. He shows commendable care in registering the exact pronunciation of every foreign name (a matter of some importance in view of the nature of the Arabic script), but in some other respects his editing is open to criticism. By his own statement the work is an abridgment, which possibly accounts for the brevity of one or two of the later sections. The bulk of the narrative has been left with but little touching-up in the simple, straightforward style of the narrator, but at points Ibn Juzayy has embellished it in the taste of the age, with passages of rhetorical prose and extracts from poems, which seldom add much of interest. His interpolation of incidents from his own experience may be excused, but another of his proceedings is more questionable. He had before him the narrative of the travels of Ibn Jubayr, an Andalusian scholar who visited Egypt, the Hijáz, and Syria in the twelfth century, and wrote an account of his experiences which enjoyed a great reputation in the West. Where Ibn Battúta covers the same ground, Ibn Juzayy has often substituted

(possibly at Ibn Battúta's desire or with his permission) an abridgment of Ibn Jubayr's work, notably in the account of the ceremonies observed at Mecca during the Pilgrimage and at other seasons of the year. We have consequently to bear in mind that the book is not entirely Ibn Battúta's work; there are indeed indications (for example, in the transcriptions and translations of Persian phrases) that the reputed author did not himself read the book at all, or if he did, read it negligently.

Taking the work, then, as a whole, we must regard it as primarily intended to present a descriptive account of Muhammadan society in the second quarter of the fourteenth century. Ibn Battúta's interest in places was, as we have seen, subordinate to his interest in persons. He is the supreme example of *le géographe malgré lui*, whose geographical knowledge was gained entirely from personal experience and the information of chance acquaintances. For his details he relied exclusively on his memory, a memory, it is true, which had been highly cultivated by the ordinary system of theological education, involving the memorizing of large numbers of works, but still liable to slips and confusions, more or less great. In his itineraries he sometimes misplaces the order of towns, and twice at least leaves himself in the air, as it were, with a gap of hundreds of miles. He gives wrong names at several points, especially when he is dealing with non-Muslim countries, where his knowledge of Arabic and Persian was of little service to him. In his historical narratives, which are generally trustworthy, similar mistakes are found. It is indeed remarkable that the errors are comparatively few, considering the enormous number of persons and places he mentions. The most serious difficulty is offered by the chronology of the travels, which is utterly impossible as it stands. Many of the dates give the impression of having been inserted

more or less at haphazard, possibly at the editor's request, but the examination and correction of them offers a task so great that it has not been attempted in this selection.

There is finally the question of his veracity. There can be no doubt that in his narratives of the Muslim countries, notwithstanding errors of exaggeration and misunderstanding, Ibn Battúta faithfully relates what he believes to be true. Some critics have, however, regarded his claim to have visited Constantinople and China with considerable dubiety. The principal difficulties as regards the visit to Constantinople are the vagueness of his route and his claim to have met the ex-Emperor, when by his own chronology the ex-Emperor had been dead for over a year. The first can be explained by the difficulties of an Arabic-speaking traveller in such unfamiliar surroundings, the second by an error in dating. The account of the city itself is so full and accurate that it cannot be other than the narrative of an eye-witness, who enjoyed exceptional facilities such as Ibn Battúta had, and his interview with the ex-Emperor in particular bears the unmistakable stamp of truth.

The difficulties contained in the narrative of the journeys to and in China are generally of the same order, and will be more fully considered in their place. It need only be said here that to deny them raises even greater difficulties, and that by exactly the same kind of reasoning it can be "proved" that though Ibn Battúta undoubtedly was *in* India he never went there! Ibn Battúta is always unsatisfactory when he relies on second-hand information, and it is most unlikely that he could have put together so personal a narrative had the statements of others not been supplemented by his own observations. There are also some material arguments in favour of his claim to have visited China. He had, in his capacity as envoy

from the Sultan of Delhi, very good reason for going there, and facilities for travel in China which were denied to the ordinary merchant. In the second place one obscure passage in the narrative of his doings at Khansa (Hang-chow) is cleared up by an earlier passage relating to his visit to Shaykh Jalál ad-Dín in Assam, with which the journey to China is closely connected. Thirdly, if his claim were false, he stood a reasonable chance of being exposed. He relates with some emphasis that in his journey through Northern China he met a merchant from Ceuta, the brother of a man living in Sijilmása, in Morocco, whom he subsequently met also. That this merchant should have had some communication with Morocco, even in those days, is not impossible, since Ibn Battúta himself had once transmitted a sum of money from India to Mequinez. On the whole, therefore, the narrative dealing with China seems to me to be genuine, though it is certainly related with greater brevity than usual, either because Ibn Battúta could not recall the Chinese names, if he learned them, with the same ease as the more familiar Arabic and Persian names, or because it was more drastically abridged by the editor. I can in fact see no alternative, except to suppose that he was hypnotized into the belief that he had gone there by one of the miracle-working saints whom he met in India.

Ibn Battúta was first brought into prominence by the translation of an abridged text by Dr. Samuel Lee in 1829. The complete text of the Travels, which was found in Algeria a few years later, was published with a French translation and critical apparatus by Defrémery and Sanguinetti in the middle of the century from a number of manuscripts, one of which, containing the second half of the work, is the autograph of the original editor, Ibn Juzayy. The French translation, though on the whole remarkably accurate,

suffers from the absence of explanatory notes. Various sections of the book (chiefly from the French text) have been annotated by scholars familiar with the countries themselves, but a large amount still remains to be worked over. In the present selections, which have been translated afresh from the Arabic text, Ibn Battúta is treated as a traveller, and not as a writer of geography. Sufficient indications have, it is hoped, been added in the text and the notes to enable the course of his journeys to be followed in detail on any large-scale atlas, but many problems of geography have been passed over in silence. The easy colloquialism of his style has been retained in translation as far as possible, in preference to a stilted Elizabethan language. It has not been easy to make a selection from the wealth of narrative and anecdote contained in the work, and many interesting sections have necessarily been omitted or abridged. But until the appearance of a complete version (such as the writer is now preparing for the Hakluyt Society) it is hoped that this extract may be of service in introducing to a wider circle of English readers one of the most remarkable travellers of his own or any age.

## § 2. THE HISTORICAL BACKGROUND OF IBN BATTÚTA'S TRAVELS

The Islamic world in the fourteenth century differed, in extent and outward splendour, but little from the magnificent empire ruled by the Caliphs of Damascus and Baghdád in the eighth. If in the West it had been shorn of its outposts in Spain and Sicily, it could justly claim to have more than balanced the loss by its extension in India and Malaysia. It had recently wiped out the last traces of the humiliation inflicted upon it by the crusading Franks, and was on the point of exacting a signal vengeance by the sword of

the Ottomans in Europe. Yet it was true, notwithstanding all these apparent signs of progress, that the political fabric of Islám was stricken with mortal disease. The centuries had taken a heavy toll of vitality from that huge frame, and had left it still formidable, it may be, but wounded at the heart.

The last Crusader had indeed been driven from the shores of Syria, but at what a cost! Two centuries of struggle and intrigue had been necessary to repel attacks that the warriors of the early generations had regarded as the minor incidents of outpost warfare. The sceptre had passed from the hands of the supple Arab and the cultured Persian to those of the violent and illiberal Turk. For more than two centuries after the year 1000 the ambitions of Turkish generals and chieftains had torn and retorn the body of Islám, devastating its lands by their misgovernment and continual warfare more effectively than any foreign foe. Convulsion succeeded to convulsion, until at length the heathen Mongols from Central Asia made hares of the Turkish lions, and in 1258 formed the derelict eastern lands of Islam into a province of their immense empire.

This event, the shock of which seemed to the Muslim peoples like the Last Judgment of the Wrath of God, proved in the end a blessing in disguise. Once again the eastern provinces enjoyed a period of firm and relatively undisturbed government, under which commerce and agriculture took heart and began to re-create a prosperity that seemed to have vanished for ever. Simultaneously Egypt and Syria, which had withstood the Mongol onset, enjoyed under a succession of capable rulers a rare period of peace and prosperity. The Turkish captains who had hitherto quarrelled over the mangled fragments of the central provinces, were relegated to the frontiers, where they indulged their taste for warfare at the expense of the

infidel and the heathen, winning for themselves a goodly portion of the riches of this world, and the reputation of "Warriors for the Faith" to ensure their portion in the world to come. The Mongol conquests thus effectually contributed to the successes gained by the arms of Islam in India, and a few years later also in Thrace and the Balkan Peninsula, successes which were supplemented by the missionary labours of saints and darwish orders.

When in 1325 Ibn Battúta set out on his journeys, the political conditions in the Islamic lands were, in consequence, relatively stable and unusually favourable for travel. From Aswán to the frontier of Cilicia the word of the Sultan of Egypt was undisputed; the Crusaders were but a bitter memory, and relations with the Mongols, though not cordial, had not led to warfare since the last great victory of the youthful Násir at Damascus in 1303. 'Iráq and Persia still acknowledged the rule of the Mongol Il-kháns, now good Muslims, but destined soon to disappear. To the north and north-east the other Mongol khanates of the Golden Horde and of Jaghatáy were on friendly terms. Finally in India the ferocious but energetic Sultan of Delhi, Muhammad ibn Tughlaq, was imposing his overlordship on the greater part of the sub-continent. On the fringes of the great kingdoms, and in such outlying parts as Anatolia, Afghanistan, and the shores of the Indian Ocean, there existed a host of petty sultans and amírs, who acknowledged no master and maintained a precarious throne on the proceeds of trade or freebooting, but these could hardly inflict serious damage, even had they been so minded, on the Islamic community in general. Commerce proceeded freely both within and without the frontiers of Islam, in spite of heavy dues and occasional vexations; and if the indigenous industries had declined, in some cases to the point of extinction, the revival of the